HISTORY OF GRIMES COUNTY

Land of Heritage and Progress

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ive hundred acres for one. J.T. must have been a pretty enterprising and ambitious fellow, he certainly was not afraid of work, because at one time he had both a sawmill and a cotton gin. He had learned sawmilling from his dad Jesse and he and his brother Eef both owned one. (As a matter of fact this is the fourth generation of Keislers that have had a sawmill either in or around Richards.)

J.T. and Cynthia had three sons born while they lived at Bays Chapel. Thomas Edwin, George Henry and Lester Willis were the three boys who have lived almost their entire lives in Grimes County. When the youngest was only seven, they moved to the place where Lester lives now on the Richards to Shiro Road. At one time this was called Keisler Spur because it was on the railroad and the trains stopped in Richards to pick up cotton and lumber provided by the Keisler Cotton Gin and the Keisler Sawmill. Keisler Spur never did have a Post Office and General Store like Keisler, Texas did so it couldn't be called a town.

The cotton gin was moved to town on the T. & B.V. (Texas and Brazos Valley) Railroad which is now the Burlington Rock Island line that runs through Richards. The old building is still in the family, belonging to a great-grandson Mike Brame. The sawmill was moved from Bays Chapel to the Pool community and finally to the middle of town, where it still is today, by Lester and George Keisler in the late 1940's. Except for a period of time in the early 1970's when the Environmental Protection Agency shut them down for air pollution, the mill has been in operation continuously. It can be said that for the last hundred years there has been a Keisler sawmill in Grimes County. Today the great grandson of the original settler from South Carolina, Mr. George Dean Keisler owns and operates a modernized mill and is cutting crossties and board road. It is not opened to the public for a retail business. Mr. Keisler is now in partnership with his father-in-law, Mr. C.H. Shelton of Baytown.

The three Keisler boys, Edwin, George and Lester were all rather large fellows and it used to be said that the three of them could go bear hunting with just willow switches. They were all three avid baseball fans and at one time all played a lot of sandlot baseball. George played pro ball in what was once the Texas league. He pitched in an exhibition game against Babe Ruth one time. Lester played ball in college and signed a contract with the Houston Buffs. All three of them were famous in Grimes County and the surrounding areas for their ability to swing a bat. George's son Dean signed a contract with the San Francisco Giants during the late 1950's and carried on the family tradition by being a professional and amateur baseball player.

Jesse Tom and Cynthia put all three of their boys through public school in the early 1900's and sent the three off to college in the Roaring Twenties (that was quite a feat in itself). Edwin went to Sam Houston Normal Institute in Huntsville, George went to school in Mineral Springs and Lester went off to Arlington Agricultural College.

Edwin married a school teacher from Shiro, Miss Georgia Herman and they lived most of their married life in Richards. For a while they lived in Hull, Texas where he worked for the Magnolia Pipe Line. Edwin passed away in the summer of 1971. His widow, Georgia still lives in Richards.

George also married a schoolteacher, Miss Alla Lee Polstead from Huntsville. They still make their home in Richards where they have lived all of their married life. They have two children: Bettye Joyce Brame who married Don Brame from Palestine, Texas. She lives in Richards next to her Mother and Dad. They have three children Michael Alan, David George and Ronald Roy. Their son, Dean Keisler is the one that operates the sawmill in Richards. He was married to Shirley Giles from 1962-1968 and had one daughter Sandra Jean Keisler who is a senior at Navasota High School this year. He later married Diane Shelton from Baytown and they have three children Candice Lee, Amanda June and Randall Dean. They now live in Navasota.

Lester Willis Keisler was the youngest son of Cynthia and J.T. Keisler. He married Catherine Joyce of Richards and had three children: Brenda Nell Keisler Pool who has two boys Gary Dwayne and Barry Lynn. They live out in West Texas. Their son is Gary Neil Keisler who lives in Richards. He was married to Sarah McCune and they have one daughter Lori Grace Keisler. The youngest child is Cynthia Ruth Keisler Matchett. She now lives in the old Keisler homeplace on the main street of Richards with her husband Mike from Montgomery and their son, Jan Michael.

There are many things that could have been added to this brief history but time and space will not allow. Hopefully most of the information is accurate but any mistakes that have been made I take full credit for.

Diane S. Keisler

THE KELLER-MARX FAMILY

The Keller-Marx Family: Both Mr. Sam Keller and Mr. Morris Marx were born in Europe but settled in Navasota. In the latter part of the 1890s, Sam Keller married Rosa Marx, who was born in New Orleans. They had three children, Leonard Keller, Sadie Keller Nussbaum and Miriam Keller Lippman, all of whom are now dead. Mr. Marx's second wife was named Olivia.

Leonard Keller married Sophie Rosenthal, of Galveston, Texas, in about 1918 or 1919. They had three children, Olive (who married Arthur Bricker), Adrian, and Harris Lee. After about ten years, Leonard and his family moved to Baytown, where he continued to work for the Humble Company (now known as Exxon). He always considered Navasota his home. Sadie Keller Nussbaum's great grandchildren, the Dembini's, as well as Leonard Keller's great grandchildren, the Brickers and Dudneys, are sixth generation Texans.

Adrian Keller, son of Leonard and Sophie Keller, was born in Navasota, graduated from Texas A. & M., and founded the Diamond Paint Company in Houston. He is now deceased.

Harris Lee Keller, his brother, is a high ranking official with the United States Department of Education (formerly a part of the Department of Health, Education and Welfare) in Washington, D.C. He and his family live in Baltimore, Maryland.

Jeffrey Bricker, grandson of the Leonard Kellers and son of their daughter Olive and her husband, Art Bricker, is a successful international architect living in Houston with his wife and two children.

Myer Levy

KENNARD FAMILY

The Kennard family came to Grimes County as part of Stephen F. Austin's Second Colony in 1830 and settled on

land east of Anderson which they farmed. The sons of Anthony Drew Kennard subsequently received additional grants of land (located near their father's) for service in the War for Independence against Mexico.

In addition to farming, the family became involved in the area's first mercantile venture. Henry Fanthorpe, Abraham Womack, and Michael Moore Kennard purchased a stock of dry goods in New Orleans which they brought to Grimes County and sold from a store located on the premises of the old Fanthorpe Inn in what is now the town of Anderson. The venture was conducted under the firm name of "Fanthorpe, Womack and Kennard."

During later years a mercantile establishment was operated on Main Street in Anderson under the name "Kennard and Brown Mercantile Co."

Members of the Kennard family figured in the organization of the First National Bank of Anderson in 1904 and have been active in its operation to the present day. Today's Bank is housed in a new building which was completed and opened for business in 1979.

As with so many Grimes County families, latter day descendants of the Kennard family served their country during World War II. Today several live with their families in and around Anderson, and others return for warm visits.

J.K. Hurst

THE ANTHONY DREW KENNARD FAMILY

The Kennard family came to America from Scotland during the Colonial Period. Anthony Drew Kennard was born in Maryland but later settled in Tennessee where in 1808 he married Sarah Moore from Kentucky.

Kennard started to Texas in 1828 and remained on the banks of the Sabine River until 1830, suffering through many dangerous and inconvenient times. The Mexican government had closed Texas's territory to immigrants; but in 1830, when Stephen F. Austin received permits from the Mexican government to bring settlers to Texas, Anthony Drew applied for grant number 28 with Austin's second colony to Texas. He received grant number 34 surveyed in Grimes County about seven miles northeast of Anderson. The deed was granted to A.D. Kennard by Miguel Arcineiga in the town of San Felipe de Austin on November 22, 1832. Later that year, he was granted additional pasture-land, and each of his sons was granted a labor of land.

The Kennard family arrived on Gibbon's Creek on Christmas Eve 1832. This area was for years known as "Kennard's Prairie," but years later, it was sold to two brothers, William and John Roan, and has since been known as Roan's Prairie. There, the Kennard family and others had trouble with the local Indian tribes; the Mexican government gave no help in subduing the Indians, so the colonists had to organize themselves for protection.

In 1835, A.D. Kennard joined Moore's Expedition in an attempt to council with and arrange a treaty with the Tehuacana Indians. As they arrived at the Indian village, they were fired upon, and a fight ensued because the colonists were taken as a hostile force. The Indians did not give up, and Moore's men had to retreat with one dead. The colonists sought reinforcements, but when they returned to the camp, the Indians had fled.

The colonists, although not totally successful against the Indians, used the military expeditions as training which w to be very important in their impending war with Mexico. T Mexican government continued to provoke the colonis and clashes were inevitable. The troubles finally culminat in battles at Goliad and the Alamo. The Kennard fam learned of the situation at the Alamo from Dr. Anson Jon who spent the night of March seventh at the home of tl Kennards. Jones informed the men who were present of tl message sent out by the last courier from the Alamo c March third to the members of the convention at Washin ton-on-the-Brazos. The Kennard men served in the wa against Mexico and received land for their efforts.

After Texas became a republic, Indian problems did nc stop. One interesting story is told about a time when all c the men were away from the Kennard home. One of th servants discovered Indians killing the calves in a nearb pasture. She hastened to the house to inform Mrs. Kennard When Mrs. Kennard made no move to protect her property the servant became upset and cried out, "What shall we do? What shall we do?" Mrs. Kennard replied that they could do nothing but trust in the Lord. To that, the servant replied, "That is a mighty poor help when the 'Injuns' are out there killing the calves."

Mrs. Kennard was one who did put her trust in the Lord. She was instrumental in starting the Baptist Church in the area of Rocky Creek. The first church was named Antioch and was begun in 1844. There was no Anderson or Grimes County at that time, but in 1845 the church moved to what is now the site in Anderson.

Sarah and Anthony Drew had nine children; of those children, there was Rachael who married Henry Fanthrop who built Fanthrop Inn for her. Another child was Michael Moore Kennard.

Michael Moore Kennard married Mary Ann R. Womack and remained in Grimes County farm and open the first mercantile firm to do business in what is now Grimes County. They purchased stock in New Orleans, freighted it to Anderson which stood at the crossroads of the two most important stage lines in Texas: the Houston to Old Springfield line, and the Nacogdoches to Austin line.

Michael Kennard's father died in service during the Civil War, and according to family history was one of the few returned to his home for burial. When Michael died, he was thought to be the oldest resident of Grimes County.

Mary Ann and Michael had four children; one of whom was John H. Kennard who was one of the founders of the First National Bank of Anderson in 1904. He was also Tax Collector of Grimes County. After both attended college, John married Hattie Brown and one of their sons, George Brown Kennard, followed his father's footsteps into the bank and was the president.

Other children of John H. Kennard and Hattie were Stella who married Gary Thomas of Anderson; Lizzie who married Jack Hurst of Anderson; and Mary Lou. Their descendants are Kennard Thomas of Anderson; Marion Brown Thomas's children Richard Gary Thomas and children, Lee Burnett and Gary Thomas, and Mary Stewart Thomas Brumley and children, Marion, Carla, and Jon Stewart Brumley; Jack Hurst, Jr. of Austin whose children are Betty, Sharon, Thomas and Edward; and J.B. Thomas of Houston whose children are Scott and Mary Beth.

John H. Kennard was the only child of George Brown Kennard and his wife, Lillian Campbell, whose father served

in the Texas Legislature. John had one child by his first marriage, Kay Kennard McIlyar of Dallas who has four children: Kathy, Kent, Kelly and Kirby. John had two children by his marriage to Florence Albrecht: John Stephen Kennard, now of New York; and Johanna Kennard Hereford of Conroe who has one daughter, Sarah.

Johanna Kennard Hereford

THE FAMILY OF CARROLL W. KENNARD

My father, Carroll Wynne Kennard, was a descendant of Anthony Drew Kennard. Anthony Drew and his wife Sarah came to Texas in about 1830. He applied and received a land grant in 1832. They settled in Grimes County in 1832. They had nine children. One of these children, Mark L. Kennard, was my father's grandfather. He and his wife Helen had eight children, namely, William W., Mike, Permelia, Sallie, Martha, Mary, Anthony Drew, and Mark. Anthony Drew was my grandfather. He married Louella Wood of Willis, Texas and they lived in Anderson. They had six children: Lockett, Cummings, Anthony Drew (died in childhood), Evelyn, (died in infancy), Minnie, and Carroll.

Lockett married Essie Farquhar of Navasota. Lockett died in 1959 and Essie died in 1980. They had one child, Edward Cummings. Edward married Elaine Gasser of Navasota. They had four children. The oldest child, Katie Drew, and husband Joe Femino, live in Smithtown, New York with their two sons, John Edward and Andrew. Their next child, Susan Wrenn, and husband Brynn Aurelius live in Houston. They have three children; Dunham, Campbell, and Carrie. Their son, Edward C. Kennard Jr., and wife Susan (formerly Susan Ellis of Phoenix, Arizona) live in Houston. He is in the advertising business. Edward has two sons, Scott and Jonas, by a former marriage. They also have a daughter, Ashley Elizabeth, born October 8, 1981.

Edward and Elaine's fourth child, a daughter, died at birth in 1951. At present, Edward and Elaine live in Bloomfield Hills, Michigan. He is General Manager of the Cadillac Division and also one of the vice presidents of General Motors.

Cummings married Ruth Johnson of Galveston. He was in the automobile business for a number of years. They lived in La Marque. He died in June, 1978. Cummings and Ruth had three children. The oldest child, Jimmy, died at the age of ten in 1943. They had two other children, William Walker (Bill) and Gail Knight. Bill married Susan Johnson of Humble and they have one child, Sarah. Bill is with the school system in New Caney. He lives in Conroe. Gail married Stan Coffee of Houston. They have two children, Cara Elizabeth and Lee Cummings. They recently moved from Houston to California.

Minnie married Sidney Lee Williams of Anderson. Sidney was superintendent of the Anderson School for several years. Minnie was a teacher. They moved to Dallas where Sidney was in the oil business. They are now retired and living in Conroe. Their infant daughter died at birth in 1945. They have one son, Sidney Lee (Rusty), who is with GMAC in Houston. Rusty has one daughter, Rachel.

Carroll married Elizabeth Dickenson of Navasota. They had one child, Edith Louise. She married Frank Shallene of Austin. They have three children, Martha Wynne, Stephanie, and Frank Mills II. They live in Keller, Texas.

In 1940 Carroll and Elizabeth bought some land located about two miles from Anderson. Later, they built a weekend house on this land. They moved to Texas City in 1941. Carroll was in the automobile and tractor business. In 1977 they moved back to Anderson where they now live.

My grandfather, Anthony Drew, was a stockman. My father was intrigued by the cattle business just like his father. My grandmother often told me about my father's love for cattle when he was a small boy. When the horses were fed, my father would gather up all the corn-cobs. These were his cows. Clothes were boiled outside in a large washpot. He would take a piece of haywire and get it hot in the fire under the washpot. He would brand the corn-cobs. He used string and sticks to make his pastures. He knew the brands of some of his father's friends, so he had several bunches of cattle in different little pastures.

My father tells about the cattle drives he went on with his father. They drove the cattle across the country to Franklin and Normangee.

My grandmother spent a lot of time with us when I was a little girl. She and my father often talked about "the good old days." She would tell about when they had district court in Anderson. There was a wagon yard where the courthouse annex is now. People came from all over the judicial district to attend the trials. Some of them camped in the wagon yard. It was an exciting time for both the young and the old. She never knew how many people my grandfather would bring home for dinner. They would eat in relays.

This summer we had a Kennard reunion in New Braunfels. Those able to share in the fun for three days were Minnie and Sidney Williams, their son Rusty, and granddaughter Rachel. Also there were Carroll and Elizabeth Kenanrd, daughter Edith, her husband Frank, and their three children, Martha, Stephanie, and Mills. Edward and Susan Kennard and sons, Scott and Jonas, were there. Katie, Joe, John Edward, and Andrew Femino came from New York to attend. Also, Wrenn and Brynn Aurelius and their three children, Dunham, Campbell, and Carrie were there having fun, too. Bill Kennard, wife Susan, and daughter Sarah shared a cottage with Gail and Stan Coffee and children, Cara and Lee. Stan's daughter Shannon came from Oklahoma to be with us.

Edith Kennard Shallene, Daughter of Carroll Kennard

THE EDWARD KERL AND THOMAS RUCKETT FAMILIES

Kinchon Kerl, the father of Edward W. Kerl, was born a slave. He was the property of a Mr. Peterson, who brought him to Texas from Alabama and sold him to John Flanthop.

Kinchon had two sons and a daughter: Henry, Edward and Frances Estella. Edward, the subject of this sketch, was born a slave in 1856, and was emancipated at the age of nine.

He attended private and public schools, and was quite studious. He acquired a fair knowledge of the common branches of learning, having taught school for a number of years with fairly good success.

Edward married Sarah Henson. They had five children: Estella, Rosie Lee, Johanna, Eloise, and Edward, Jr.

He bought a farm adjacent to his father and later purchased his brother's share of the inheritance.

Along with teaching, he farmed. His wife, children, and